

# Durably Sustainability Scan - Methodology

A claims-risk methodology based on EmpCo / Directive (EU) 2024/825 and the EU Forced Labour Regulation / Regulation (EU) 2024/3015.

This methodology explains how the scan identifies and scores sustainability-claim risk. It is designed for websites, product pages, marketing text, public sustainability communication and uploaded company documents. The output is an indicative risk-screening result, not legal advice and not a legal finding of greenwashing or social washing.

## 1. What the scan assesses

The scan does not rate the company's overall ESG performance. It focuses on the quality and risk profile of sustainability claims: whether the wording is specific, substantiated, proportionate, audience-appropriate and consistent with relevant external stakeholder information.

| Assessment lens | What is reviewed                                                                                                                                | Main output                                                          |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Green claims    | Environmental, climate, carbon, circularity, recyclability, durability, comparative, future-performance, label, icon or visual claims.          | Green score and EmpCo-related red flags.                             |
| Social claims   | Human-rights, labour, forced-labour, supplier, responsible-sourcing, inclusion, worker-welfare, customer-protection or community-impact claims. | Social score and Forced Labour Regulation / due-diligence red flags. |
| Global score    | Integrated view of Green and Social claim risk.                                                                                                 | Overall claims-risk signal for management review.                    |

## 2. Regulatory and good-practice references

EmpCo / Directive (EU) 2024/825 is used as the core consumer-protection lens for environmental claims. The methodology specifically checks generic claims, carbon-neutrality and offsetting wording, self-declared sustainability labels, comparative claims, future environmental-performance claims, claims based on one product feature, and situations where legal requirements are presented as distinctive environmental benefits.

Regulation (EU) 2024/3015 on products made with forced labour is used as a specific social/product-market lens. Claims that imply products, imports, suppliers or supply chains are forced-labour free, traceable, audited or fully controlled require stronger evidence: product and supplier traceability, forced-labour risk assessment, preventive and corrective action, grievance/remedy processes, and withdrawal/customs response readiness.

| Reference                                                          | How it is used in the scan                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EmpCo / Directive (EU) 2024/825                                    | Risk lens for B2C and market-facing environmental claims, including blacklisted-practice indicators and misleading omissions/actions.                     |
| Green Claims Directive proposal / EU claim-substantiation practice | Used as a best-practice substantiation lens: claim scope, evidence quality, data sources, methodology, limitations and verification.                      |
| EU Forced Labour Regulation / Regulation (EU) 2024/3015            | Used for forced-labour, product, import/export, supplier, traceability and responsible-sourcing wording.                                                  |
| CSRD / ESRS, OECD Guidelines, UNGPs, ILO, UNGC and GRI             | Used to assess whether social claims are linked to due diligence, affected stakeholders, policies, actions, metrics, remediation and balanced disclosure. |

## 3. Claim selection: when wording is actually treated as a claim

The scan applies a contextual claim filter. A word is not automatically problematic because it appears in the text. The wording is retained only when it plausibly communicates an environmental or social benefit, assurance, comparison, outcome or level of control. This is especially important for supplier wording: a neutral sentence such as "backing British suppliers" is not treated as a supplier-responsibility claim merely because it contains "suppliers". Supplier-related wording is flagged when the surrounding context implies responsible sourcing, ethical sourcing, traceability, certification, audits, human-rights/labour controls, all-supplier coverage, due diligence or forced-labour assurance.

| Wording pattern                                              | Treatment by the methodology                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Backing British suppliers” / “working with local suppliers” | Normally not retained as a high-risk social claim unless accompanied by claims about responsibility, ethics, traceability, audit, human rights, labour standards or full supplier coverage. |
| “Responsible sourcing across our supply chain”               | Retained as a supplier-responsibility claim because it implies responsible value-chain controls and evidence expectations.                                                                  |
| “All suppliers comply with our human-rights code”            | Retained as high-risk because it combines absolute supplier coverage with a sensitive human-rights assurance.                                                                               |
| “Climate neutral product”                                    | Retained as high-risk because it may fall within EmpCo blacklisted-practice indicators where product-level neutrality is based on offsetting.                                               |
| Leaf, planet, eco badge or green label icons                 | Reviewed as visual environmental claim indicators where they imply a sustainability benefit.                                                                                                |

## 4. Score calculation

Each dimension score is calculated from four primary drivers plus targeted regulatory modifiers. The score is a risk score: higher means a greater need for evidence review, wording review or legal/compliance review before the claim is reused externally.

| Score driver                          | Weight | How it is assessed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Claim wording risk                    | 34%    | Sensitivity of the wording: generic, absolute, future-oriented, comparative, product-level climate neutral, label/certification, responsible-sourcing, human-rights, forced-labour or all-supplier wording. Contextual filters reduce false positives from neutral references.                           |
| Evidence-gap risk                     | 32%    | Whether the source text provides scope, methodology, KPIs, percentage data, baseline, reporting period, limitations, verification, audit coverage, traceability, grievance/remedy or corrective-action evidence.                                                                                         |
| Negative external stakeholder context | 22%    | Only retained negative stakeholder signals count: criticism, allegations, NGO/union concerns, regulator/enforcement action, litigation, complaints, investigations or clearly negative press. Company-owned documents, policies, reports, press releases, awards and positive/neutral news are excluded. |
| Sector and channel sensitivity        | 12%    | Higher baseline sensitivity for sectors or channels with structural exposure, and for client-facing/consumer-facing material under EmpCo. Investor reports and internal policy documents are mainly used as evidence and consistency sources.                                                            |

### Regulatory modifiers and interpretive caps

A direct EmpCo or Forced Labour Regulation signal can increase the relevant dimension score. Examples include product-level climate-neutrality based on offsetting, self-declared sustainability labels, generic environmental claims without clear same-medium specification, legal requirements presented as green benefits, forced-labour-free product claims, product/supplier traceability claims, and absolute supplier-control language. At the same time, the methodology applies interpretive caps so that weak, neutral or unsubstantiated keyword hits do not automatically become High risk. High-risk conclusions require a meaningful combination of problematic wording, evidence gaps, regulatory sensitivity or negative external stakeholder context.

### Green score

The Green score focuses on environmental and climate-claim risk. It is highest where consumer-facing or market-facing wording contains high-sensitivity EmpCo indicators and lacks clear same-medium specification or objective evidence. Examples: “eco-friendly”, “climate neutral”, “net zero product”, “100% sustainable”, “green certified”, “more sustainable than”, “lowest emissions”, or an environmental icon/badge that implies a broader benefit than the evidence supports.

### Social score

The Social score focuses on human-rights, labour, supply-chain, worker, customer and community claim risk. A claim is not flagged only because the word “supplier” appears. Supplier-related wording is assessed as material only when it implies responsible sourcing, ethical sourcing, traceability, audits, certification, all-supplier coverage, human-rights/labour assurance, forced-labour controls or similar levels of control. Forced-labour and modern-slavery product or supplier claims receive a higher regulatory weighting.

## Global score

The Global score integrates the Green and Social scores. It gives more weight to the stronger risk dimension but does not simply copy the highest score. The Global score is intended as a management-level prioritisation signal; users should still review the separate Green and Social scorecards because the underlying claim issues and evidence requirements differ.

## 5. Source and exact detected wording

Each retained claim signal should be read as a structured claim card, not as a loose keyword result. The report shows: (1) the source page/document/link; (2) the exact retained passage; (3) the specific trigger phrase(s) highlighted in that passage; (4) why the passage was retained; and (5) the suggested improvement. If no standalone trigger word is highlighted, the passage was retained because the complete wording pattern - not a single word - may imply a sustainability claim in context.

Users should always check the source link and nearby context. The scan is designed to prioritise review; it does not replace human judgement, legal interpretation or subject-matter verification.

## 6. Negative external stakeholder signals

External public-source signals are deliberately narrow. The scan retains only negative or risk-relevant stakeholder perceptions when they appear company-specific and aligned with the claim area. Examples include NGO concerns, union criticism, regulator investigations, court cases, complaints, enforcement actions, adverse media investigations, allegations of misleading claims, greenwashing criticism or labour-rights controversies.

The external section excludes company-owned sustainability reports, annual reports, policies, supplier codes, human-rights statements, corporate press releases, product launches, awards, partnerships, positive announcements and neutral corporate news. These sources may be useful as evidence, but they are not external stakeholder signals and should not raise the external-context component.

| Included in external stakeholder signals                                                                                  | Excluded from external stakeholder signals                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NGO, union, regulator, court, complaint, investigation, litigation, enforcement, negative press or stakeholder criticism. | Company sustainability reports, policies, supplier codes, own press releases, corporate news, awards, partnerships, product launches, investor presentations and neutral/positive articles. |

## 7. Visual and icon review

The scan reviews visible text and available HTML signals such as alt text, titles, class names, file names and image references for cues like leaf, planet, eco badge, recycled, carbon, climate, green label or certification-style language. These cues are treated as potential visual claim indicators only when they appear to imply an environmental benefit. Manual review remains necessary for packaging or image-heavy pages because automated extraction may miss embedded text or design context.

## 8. Practical interpretation of scores

| Range  | Interpretation                                  | Recommended response                                                                    |
|--------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0-29   | Low claim-risk signal.                          | Standard evidence retention and periodic review.                                        |
| 30-49  | Potentially overbroad or under-specified claim. | Check wording, scope, evidence and audience.                                            |
| 50-69  | Potential greenwashing/social-washing concern.  | Prioritise evidence review, legal/compliance review and claim rewriting.                |
| 70-100 | High-priority risk signal.                      | Do not reuse externally without claim owner, legal/compliance review and evidence file. |

## 9. Limitations

The scan is an automated first-pass review. It may miss claims embedded in images, PDFs, videos, social posts, paywalled sources or dynamically loaded pages. It may also require manual refinement where a word has multiple meanings. Results should be validated by legal, compliance, sustainability and communication experts before external use.